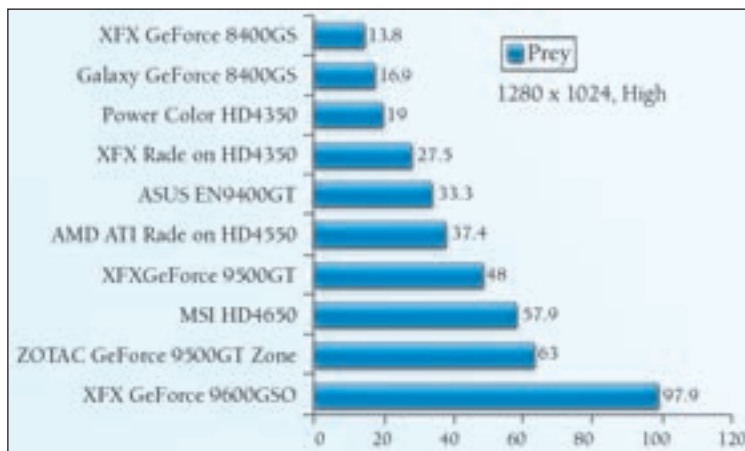
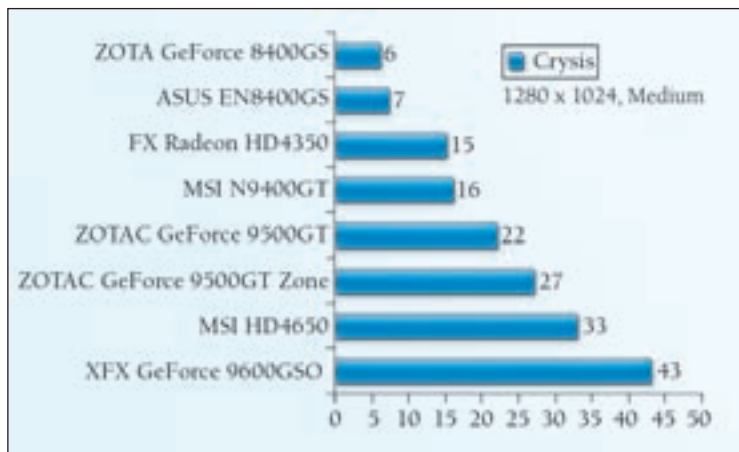


Depth of field

When a particular object within a scene needs to be in focus, that area is kept sharp while the surroundings retain a slight blur so that the eye will fall on that object first. This feature in games is called Depth of Field



reads either 'I'm gaming do not disturb' or 'Do not disturb I'm gaming' with images of the XXFX Alpha Dog or of some weapons. The XXFX GeForce 9600GSO also comes with a 3D Mark Vantage Advanced Key, you'll still need to download the benchmark.

ZOTAC has provided

a 10 per cent discount coupon with the GeForce 9500GT 1GB that can either be used to purchase any five games from the NVIDIA store, or five PhysX applications.

Performance

Amongst the NVIDIA 8400GS, the Galaxy GeForce 8400GS achieved the maximum performance score. This was also the only 8400GS that was able to successfully complete the 3D Mark Vantage benchmark.

Coincidentally, the Galaxy GeForce 8400GS is also the cheapest graphic card in this test. On the AMD side of things, the XXFX Radeon HD4350 is equal to or in some cases better than the NVIDIA 9400GTs that we tested from MSI, ZOTAC,

Galaxy, Palit and ASUS. The temperature of this passively cooled card at idle was recorded at 39 degrees Celsius, but under load it went up to 61 degrees, which might cause a problem if you intend to stress out the card almost all the time.

The best performer award under this category goes to the XXFX GeForce 9600GSO. The 9600GSOs come with the G92 GPU (the same used on 9800GTs) and has 96 stream processors – 16 stream processors less than a 9800GT. The GeForce 9600 GSO 512 is slightly different than this particular 9600 GSO, as it differs in the number of stream processors (48), and uses 512 MB DDR3 memory instead of the DDR2 that comes with the standard 9600 GSO. Also, unlike the 9800GT, this graphic card comes with DDR2 memory instead of DDR3. With XXFX's slim cooling solution, the card kept cool at 54

degrees Celsius under load and 38 degrees Celsius at idle. There were a few problems we encountered with this particular piece though – it caused the test PC to crash a couple of times when we were trying to run the Tom

Clancy's H.A.W.X benchmark at 1280 x 1024 resolution, and the next problem that we faced was the excessive noise from the fan. This could have been a problem with only this particular card and not the whole line.

The next best performers were the ZOTAC GeForce 9500GT Zone Edition and very close to that was the MSI HD4650.

The XXFX GeForce 9500GT, with 512MB DDR2 memory, being a low profile card, performed on a par with other 9500GTs with similar configurations. The only doubt we have with this particular card is the cooling solution as the temperature under idle was 43 degrees, but under load went up to 69 degrees Celsius, but the outer body of the cooling provided was cool to the touch.

The ASUS EAH4550 was another low profile card which performed on a par with the AMD 4550, but at the same time it did better than the 9400GTs, but could not match up with the 9500GTs.

Mid-range graphic cards priced at Rs. 5,000 and above

Now for those of you who thought they had to spend a bit more on a graphics card., the NVIDIA s, 9800GTs GTS250, and ATI's HD 4850 can now be purchased within this price bracket albeit

HTPC LIMITATIONS

The main limitation when setting up an HTPC is the lack of expansion slots on the motherboard, since the motherboard is most likely going to be of the mini-ITX form factor. Some motherboards come with PCIe x16 slots – in that case you need not worry about what type of card to purchase. But there are some motherboards which come with either a PCI slot or a PCIe x1 slot as the only option for expansion. No need to get too worried, as even in such cases there are graphic cards that can come to your aid as you have a few cards based on

PCI and PCIe x1 slots.

We received two such cards from TAG (Technology and Gadgets) based on the 8400GS, and though the benchmark results are mentioned in the table, we haven't included them in our comparison for the simple reason that they are on a different interface, which will be affecting the scores. The TAG 8400GS PCI card is priced at Rs. 3,500, whereas the TAG 8400GS PCIe card is priced at Rs. 5,000 – this is a premium for something that you could get for less than half the price, but since these are not the regular cards, the cost goes up.